

GB

British Phrasal Verbs

From C1 to C2 · A Progressive Glossary

60 essential-to-advanced phrasal verbs with a clear English definition and two example sentences each — arranged from foundations to proficiency-level, idiomatic usage.

B2→C1

C1

C1→C2

C2

Advanced English study pack

How to use this glossary

A **phrasal verb** is a verb combined with one or two particles (a preposition and/or an adverb), e.g. *look into*, *put up with*. Their meaning is often **idiomatic** — you cannot always guess it from the individual words — which is exactly why they are so important at C1–C2 level, where natural, native-like English is expected.

Separable vs. inseparable

- **Separable:** an object can go between the verb and the particle. *Turn the radio down / turn it down*. With a pronoun, separation is compulsory: *turn it down* (not *turn down it*).
- **Inseparable:** the particle stays with the verb. *look into the matter / look into it* (not *look it into*).

Register matters

Many phrasal verbs are neutral or informal and sound natural in speech. In **formal writing**, a single-word (often Latin-based) synonym is sometimes preferred: *carry out* → *conduct*, *find out* → *ascertain*, *put off* → *postpone*. Items marked **informal** or **BrE** are best kept for conversation and informal texts.

Study tip: don't just memorise the meaning — learn each phrasal verb *inside a sentence*. Cover the definitions, read the examples, and try to produce your own two sentences for each one. Work through the four levels in order.

Level 1 · Foundations (B2 → C1) — 15 verbs

Level 2 · Building fluency (C1) — 15 verbs

Level 3 · Advanced (C1 → C2) — 15 verbs

Level 4 · Proficiency & idiomatic, British (C2) — 15 verbs

Foundations

get by *manage, survive*

To manage to live or cope with the limited money, skills or resources you have.

- " It's tight, but we get by on what we earn.
- " He gets by in Spanish well enough to order a meal.

put off *postpone; discourage*

(1) To postpone something to a later time. (2) To make someone lose enthusiasm or feel disgust.

- " They've put the wedding off until next spring.
- " The gory details rather put me off my dinner.

turn up *arrive; increase*

(1) To arrive or appear, often unexpectedly. (2) To increase the level of sound, heat, etc.

- " She turned up at the party without an invitation.
- " Turn the music up — I love this song.

come across *find by chance; seem*

(1) To find or meet something/someone by chance. (2) To give a particular impression.

- " I came across your letter while tidying the drawer.
- " He comes across as confident, but he's actually quite nervous.

sort out *resolve, organise*

To organise, tidy or resolve a problem, mess or disagreement.

- " Give me a day to sort out the paperwork.
- " They finally sorted out their differences.

look into *investigate*

To examine or investigate a matter in order to find out the facts.

- " The manager promised to look into the mistake.
- " We're looking into cheaper suppliers.

carry on *continue*

To continue doing something, especially after an interruption.

- " Carry on — I didn't mean to interrupt.
- " She carried on working despite feeling unwell.

work out *solve; exercise; succeed*

(1) To find a solution or calculate. (2) To do physical exercise. (3) To develop in a successful way.

- " I can't work out how much we owe.
- " It all worked out for the best in the end.

bring up *mention; raise a child*

(1) To introduce or mention a subject. (2) To raise and care for a child.

- " Don't bring up politics at dinner.
- " She was brought up in a small Yorkshire village.

give up *quit, surrender*

To stop trying to do something, or to stop a habit.

- " I gave up chocolate for Lent.
- " Don't give up — you're so close.

run out of *have none left*

To use all of something so that there is none left.

- " We've run out of coffee again.
- " Hurry — we're running out of time.

take up *start; occupy*

(1) To start a hobby or activity. (2) To fill or occupy time or space.

- " He's taken up cycling to keep fit.
- " These files take up too much space.

set off *depart; trigger*

(1) To begin a journey. (2) To cause something to start, especially an alarm or reaction.

- " We set off early to avoid the rush hour.
- " The dust set off his allergies.

put up with *tolerate*

To tolerate or accept something unpleasant without complaining.

- " I won't put up with rudeness.
- " How do you put up with all that noise?

get on with *relate to; progress*

(1) To have a friendly relationship with someone. (2) To continue or make progress with a task.

- " The two of them get on like a house on fire.
- " I'd better get on with my essay.

Building fluency

put forward *propose*

To propose an idea, plan or candidate for others to consider.

- " She put forward a bold proposal to cut costs.
- " His name was put forward for the committee.

carry out *perform, complete*

To perform or complete a task, order, or piece of work.

- " Engineers carried out a thorough inspection.
- " The orders were carried out to the letter.

point out *draw attention to*

To make someone aware of a fact or detail they may not have noticed.

- " He pointed out that the deadline had already passed.
- " May I point out one small error?

rule out *exclude*

To exclude something as a possibility or option.

- " Police haven't ruled out foul play.
- " The injury ruled her out of the final.

come up with *produce an idea*

To produce or think of an idea, plan or solution.

- " We need to come up with a plan by Monday.
- " She came up with a brilliant title for the book.

cut down on *reduce*

To reduce the amount or frequency of something.

- " I'm trying to cut down on sugar.
- " They've cut down on unnecessary spending.

look forward to *anticipate with pleasure*

To feel pleased and excited about something that is going to happen.

- " I'm really looking forward to the weekend.
- " We look forward to hearing from you.

get away with *escape blame*

To avoid punishment or blame for something you have done.

- " He cheated and somehow got away with it.
- " You won't get away with being late again.

turn down *reject; lower*

(1) To reject or refuse an offer or request. (2) To reduce sound, heat, etc.

- " She turned down the job offer.
- " Could you turn the telly down?

back up *support; copy*

(1) To support someone or confirm what they say. (2) To make a spare copy of data.

- " Her colleagues backed up her version of events.
- " Always back up your files before updating.

break down *fail; collapse; analyse*

(1) To stop functioning. (2) To lose emotional control. (3) To separate into smaller parts.

- " The car broke down on the motorway.
- " He broke down in tears at the news.

make up for *compensate*

To compensate for something bad or missing.

- " Nothing can make up for lost time.
- " He bought flowers to make up for forgetting the date.

stand out *be prominent*

To be clearly noticeable or much better than the rest.

- " Her application stood out from the rest.
- " One detail stands out in my memory.

hold up *delay; rob*

(1) To delay or slow something down. (2) To rob a place using threat or force.

- " Roadworks held up the traffic for miles.
- " Two men held up the bank in broad daylight.

take on *accept; employ; acquire*

(1) To accept work or responsibility. (2) To employ someone. (3) To begin to have a quality.

- " She's taken on far too much this term.
- " The firm is taking on new staff.

Advanced

wear off *fade gradually*

(Of an effect or feeling) to disappear slowly over time.

- " The anaesthetic slowly wore off.
- " The novelty of the new phone soon wore off.

come round *revive; be persuaded* **BrE**

(1) To regain consciousness. (2) To change your mind and agree. (3) To visit someone informally.

- " It took her a few minutes to come round after fainting.
- " He eventually came round to our way of thinking.

bring about *cause*

To make something happen; to cause a change.

- " The reforms brought about lasting change.
- " What brought about this sudden decision?

do away with *abolish*

To abolish, remove or get rid of something.

- " The school did away with compulsory uniforms.
- " These outdated rules should be done away with.

fall through *fail to happen*

(Of a plan, deal or arrangement) to fail to be completed.

- " The house sale fell through at the last minute.
- " Our holiday plans fell through.

gloss over *minimise, skate over*

To avoid dealing with something properly by mentioning it only briefly.

- " The report glossed over the safety concerns.
- " He glossed over his own mistakes.

iron out *resolve difficulties*

To resolve small problems or disagreements so that something runs smoothly.

- " We still have a few details to iron out.
- " They ironed out their differences over coffee.

wind up *end up; tease; close* **BrE informal**

(1) To end up in a state or place. (2) To tease or annoy someone. (3) To close down a company.

- " If you're not careful, you'll wind up in trouble.
- " Stop winding your brother up!

tail off *decrease gradually*

To become gradually smaller, weaker or quieter and then stop.

- " Sales tailed off after Christmas.
- " Her voice tailed off into a whisper.

branch out *expand into*

To extend your activities into a new and different area.

- " The bakery has branched out into catering.
- " She branched out from acting into directing.

bank on *rely on*

To rely on or feel confident that something will happen.

- " Don't bank on the weather staying fine.
- " We were banking on him to close the deal.

stumble across *discover by chance*

To find or discover something unexpectedly and by chance.

- " I stumbled across a lovely little café down a side street.
- " Researchers stumbled across the fossil by accident.

knuckle down *start working hard*

To begin to work seriously and with effort.

- " It's time to knuckle down and revise.
- " If we knuckle down, we'll finish by tonight.

shrug off *dismiss*

To treat something as unimportant and not let it affect you.

- " She shrugged off the criticism with a smile.
- " He shrugged off the injury and carried on playing.

rope in *recruit reluctantly* **informal**

To persuade someone to take part in an activity, often when they are reluctant.

- " I got roped into helping with the school fair.
- " They roped in a few friends to move the piano.

Proficiency & idiomatic (British)

cotton on (to) *start to understand* **informal**

To begin to understand or realise something, often slowly.

- " It took him a while to cotton on to the joke.
- " She soon cottoned on to what they were up to.

catch on *grasp; become popular*

(1) To understand something. (2) To become popular or fashionable.

- " The children caught on to the rules quickly.
- " The trend never really caught on in Britain.

faff about / around *waste time* **BrE informal**

To spend time doing things in a disorganised, fussy and unproductive way.

- " Stop faffing about and get in the car!
- " We faffed around for ages trying to park.

chivvy along *hurry someone* **BrE**

To encourage or urge someone to hurry up or get on with something.

- " The teacher chivvied the stragglers along.
- " I had to chivvy him along or we'd have missed the train.

fob off *deceive with excuses*

To deceive someone into accepting something inferior, or to put them off with excuses.

- " Don't let them fob you off with a cheap replacement.
- " He fobbed me off with yet another excuse.

palm off *unload by deceit*

To persuade someone to accept something unwanted, usually by deception.

- " They palmed off the faulty goods on unsuspecting tourists.
- " She palmed the boring task off on a colleague.

wriggle out of *evade cleverly*

To avoid doing something you should do, by using clever excuses.

- " He always wriggles out of doing the washing-up.
- " You can't wriggle out of your responsibilities.

hark back to *recall an earlier time*

To recall, mention or be reminiscent of something from the past.

- " The décor harks back to the 1920s.
- " He's always harking back to his university days.

egg on *urge (unwisely)*

To strongly encourage someone to do something, often something foolish.

- " The crowd egged the two of them on.
- " His mates egged him on to jump in the river.

rustle up *produce quickly* **informal**

To make or produce something quickly, especially a meal, from what is available.

- " I'll rustle up a quick omelette.
- " She rustled up a costume from odds and ends.

muck about / around *behave foolishly* **BrE informal**

To behave in a silly way or waste time instead of being useful.

- " The boys were mucking about at the back of the class.
- " Stop mucking around — we've got work to do.

own up (to) *confess*

To admit honestly that you have done something wrong.

- " Nobody would own up to breaking the window.
- " She owned up to the mistake straight away.

sound out *test opinion discreetly*

To discreetly find out someone's opinions or intentions before acting.

- " Let me sound out the committee before we decide.
- " They sounded him out about a possible transfer.

talk down to *patronise*

To speak to someone as if they were less intelligent or important than you.

- " I hate the way he talks down to the interns.
- " She never talks down to her students.

live up to *meet expectations*

To be as good as what was expected, promised or hoped for.

- " The film didn't quite live up to the hype.
- " She worked hard to live up to her parents' expectations.